THE CROWN · COUNCIL RULING

Three drafts, two loops, one razor

Drafts A, B and C run through a game-design loop, a game-theory loop and an architecture check. The council then names what the Crown cannot lose, and the Musk razor cuts the rest.

1 · The loops

Question	A · High Sanctum (Tolkien)	B · Still Centre (Le Guin)	C · Concord Harbor (Hobb)	Takes it
Game design loop				
Climax you can read	Always climbing, goal always in sight.	Flat until the very end.	Road is clear, but a town dulls the awe.	**A**
Tests mastery	Interior gates test each isle's pillar.	Open-air trials test each pillar.	Bounties — weak test.	**B (A's test, cheaper)**
Mystery of the last island	Ruins and silence.	Wild and sacred.	Ordinary — people live here.	**B**
Why the blight happened	Ruins hint at it.	Not explained.	Sap-works: the kingdom tapped the tree.	**C**
Game theory loop				
Choice structure	A forced chain: one path.	Three parallel goals: six valid orders.	A bounty menu.	**B**
Co-op incentive	Stay together throughout.	Split, then converge on a bell that needs everyone — pure coordination, no one can carry or defect.	Social hub; little shared goal.	**B**
Reason to come back	None.	None.	An economy — but it competes with Oakshire's market for the same visits.	**Oakshire already does this**
Architecture check				
Areas to build	12	11	13	**B**
Interior dungeons (excl. raid)	3	0	0	**B / C**
New load seams	0	0	3 guild skiffs	**A / B**
NPC states	Low	Low	~20 (town)	**A / B**

Verdict: B's structure, A's vertical climax (up the mountain, then down to the roots), C's cause for the blight — and no town.

2 · What the Crown cannot lose

Each item had to earn its place twice: as game design, and as something that would really be so.

1. **One landing, in the south bay. Design:** the Master Atlas's single seam. **Logic:** the bay is the gully the summit stream cut — the only gentle beach on a dome.
2. **The tree in sight from every step. Design:** a landmark you navigate by, so a 9-year-old never gets lost. **Logic:** it is the tallest thing for 5 km, fed by the springs.
3. **Three Sign shores where the currents land, in any order.** Le Guin. **Design:** supports online split play. **Logic:** each current carries its isle's water — warm and iron-red to the west, cold wind to the north, dark tide to the east — so each shore takes on its isle's character.
4. **Each trial is a remix, not a new system.** Tolkien. **Design:** capstones test mastery; nothing new to teach at Lv 15. Posture breaks in the west, wind-shear mobility in the north, darkness and cleansing in the east.
5. **The +32 m cliff band is the wall; one stair climbs it. Design:** an honest boundary instead of invisible walls, and Tolkien's climb survives as the final ascent. **Logic:** dome flanks steepen where the old crust broke.
6. **The bell is rung together.** Le Guin. **Game theory:** every player must act at once — a coordination game nobody can carry alone or opt out of.
7. **Up to ring, down to break.** Tolkien. **Design:** the Ebb pays off on the Crown itself; the raid door sits at sea level and descends under the summit. **Logic:** sea-caves at the old waterline.
8. **Warm springs are checkpoints. Design:** three respawn points with no new system. **Logic:** the dome is still warm — the same heat that lets the tree live.
9. **Ruins explain the blight.** Hobb + Tolkien. **Design:** environmental storytelling only. **Logic:** the old kingdom tapped the tree's sap; the Star-Tide is the wound bleeding into the sea.
10. **No town on the Crown.** Hobb conceded. **Design:** Oakshire is the hub; a second one splits the player's attention and kills the mystery. **Logic:** nobody could land here until the currents calmed.

3 · The Musk razor

Delete every part you can. If you are not adding back about 10%, you did not delete enough.

Deleted

- **3 interior gate dungeons** (A) → open-air trials.
- **Fixed W → N → E order** (A) → any order.
- **Processional spiral road** (A) → ring path + one stair.
- **Three named ruin sites** (A) → ruin dressing at each trial.
- **Grove Ring of stones** (B) → the cliff band is the wall.
- **Tidal ring of elites** (B) → the Ebb here bares only the raid door.
- **Warden's House** (B) → merged into the waypost.
- **Concord Harbor town** (C) → none.
- **Glasshouses, bathhouse** (C) → springs as checkpoints.
- **3 guild piers** (C) → none; 3 seams saved.
- **Tree Road, bounty board, bell-tower** (C) → the bell hangs in the tree.

Added back (the 10%)

- **The Ebb cinematic.** Ringing the bell cuts across all five isles for about 10 seconds as the sea falls. It reuses every map and is the biggest payoff in the game for one camera sequence.
- **The tree answers each trial.** One bough blossoms in that Sign's colour, visible from North Quay. One shader parameter makes progress visible from home.

11–13 → 7 areas	3 → 0 interior dungeons
0 new seams	+3 booleans: one per trial